

UNITY IN DIVERSITY

Born out of necessity and antiquated local customs, a unique experiment brings together Muslim brides from West Bengal and grooms from the Kutch region in Gujarat

Photographs by SHAILESH NAVAL



NOORMOHAMMED BAKHAR JAT, 32
Married
Shabana
Ansari, 29,
the daughter
of a widow,
from a village
in Dhanbad

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Kutch takes pride in its diversity but the latest trend is rather unusual. Bengali Muslim girls, who can neither understand Kutchi—the local language—nor relate to local customs are marrying Kutchi Muslims. Numbering over 1,000, the girls hail from the Bihar-West Bengal border. The unique merger has been forged by two factors: the poor financial condition of Bengali Muslim families and the paucity of Kutchi Muslim girls due to

an age-old custom—*Sata*—in which a Kutchi groom can get a bride only if he has a sister to give to his prospective in-laws. Men without sisters are condemned to remain bachelors. Tolu Khan, 22, from the Jat Muslim tribe which is well known for embroidery, faced the same fate till he married Zakira Zahur Pathan, 19, daughter of a poverty-stricken industry worker of Bankura in West Bengal. Three months back, the daily wage-cum-cattle owner of village Tal in the Banni area of Kutch married Zakira after she

and her family undertook a three-day train journey to reach Tal after Tolu paid Rs 10,000 for the travel. Says a blushing Zakira in broken Hindi: "I have heard Kutchis are very good people, so I am not anxious." Her father earns Rs 40 a day in a cement factory in Bankura and has four daughters, two still unmarried.

Tolu's quest was inspired by Karim Khan, 32, a teacher and health worker, and his wife Saira Khatun who belongs to Asansol in West Bengal. They got married in 2000, have two sons and say that they are happy. Saira now speaks Kutchi fluently. Nearby, Shabana Ansari, 29, daughter of a widow from Dhanbad, is married to Noormohammed Bakhar Jat, 32. Her mother had heard of poor Muslim Bengali girls getting married in Kutch and established contact with a middleman. Shabana, who also excels in Kutchi embroidery, says: "I got married this far due to extreme poverty but I am happy."

One reason why this trend has become popular now, almost a decade later, is that most Bengali girls have proved good housewives. Brought up

NOORMOHAMMED JAKAB KUNGHRA, 42
A fisherman
and a widower,
he married
Shamima Nazim
Ansari, 26,
of Asansol,
West Bengal

